

Hackles Teacher Academy: Overview and Learning Path

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

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FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org

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A free, self-paced course that teaches teachers how to teach cybersecurity and online safety. No technical background needed. Bring a cup of something warm.

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No student accounts, no student data collected, ever. The Academy holds itself to the same rule for teachers: no logins, no tracking, nothing leaving your hands, and your pre- and post-surveys, quizzes and capstone stay on your own paper or your own device.

Welcome

MAYBE A PRINCIPAL HANDED you this course and said, "We need someone to teach the online safety lessons." Maybe you're the science teacher who once reset a router and is now the unofficial IT department. Maybe you teach fifth grade and your students know more about Roblox than you know about your own phone. Or maybe you teach computing, you know a great deal about networks, and nobody has ever shown you how to talk with a ten-year-old about a stranger in a game chat.

Every one of you is in the right place, because the Academy rests on one idea that surprises people:

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
Teaching online safety well is mostly teaching skills, not technology. Apps change every year. The human skills do not: notice that something feels off, pause, check, and tell a trusted adult, without shame. If you can listen, stay calm, and run a good 15-minute activity, you can teach this.	

The Academy matches the Hackles kit exactly. The routine you learn is the routine your students learn: **Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.** The lesson format you practice is the 15-minute format in the Teacher Guides for K-2, 3-5, 6-8 and 9-12, and the disclosure steps you rehearse are the ones in the Disclosure and Incident Guide.

It also tries to practice what it preaches. Every module is bite-sized, active and a little bit fun, because lectures about lectures don't work. (The evidence is in Module 1 and Module 4. Yes, we know it's ironic to put that in text.)

Who this is for

- **Classroom teachers K-12** assigned to deliver Hackles lessons, including those with zero background.
- **Specialists and librarians** (library media, art, PE, music) who see every child in the school.
- **School counselors, social workers and administrators** who support teachers or run the program.
- **Computing and CS teachers** who know the technology and want to turn it into effective instruction (the Specialist pathway).
- **PD leaders and instructional coaches** who want a ready-made, free course to run with a staff.
- **Student teachers and teacher candidates.**

YOU DON'T NEED TO be a Hackles school to get something out of this. The examples, lesson formats and scripts do refer to the kit, though.

What you will be able to do

BY THE END OF the Full pathway you will be able to:

1. Explain, calmly and accurately, what risks children actually face online, and say what the evidence does and does not tell us.
2. Do the basic cybersecurity moves yourself (strong passwords and passkeys, spotting phishing, privacy settings, updates, backups) and teach them in plain language.
3. Talk with students about their online lives with curiosity instead of judgment.
4. Choose and design lessons that build skills (rehearsal, role-play) instead of delivering warnings.
5. Run a smooth 15-minute Hackles lesson, including the questioning and classroom management moves.
6. Respond well in the first 10 minutes after a disclosure, report as required, and look after yourself.
7. Include every learner and every family, and respond to parent concerns without defensiveness.
8. Measure whether your teaching is working and keep improving.

How the Academy is organized

PART	WHAT IT IS	TIME
Module 1: Why this matters	The real threats, the evidence, and why we do not use fear	about 60 min
Module 2: The cybersecurity you need	Passwords, phishing, privacy, updates, backups. Hands-on, fake data only	about 75 min
Module 3: How kids really live online	Games, group chats, AI companions, short video; the curiosity script	about 60 min
Module 4: Teaching safety that works	Skills over info, rehearsal, no fear appeals, shame-free language, spiral curriculum, fun	about 65 min
Module 5: Running a 15-minute Hackles lesson	Anatomy, timing, facilitation, questioning, management; a full micro-teach with rubric	about 70 min
Module 6: Sensitive topics and disclosures	Mandated reporting basics, the First 10 Minutes, role-play, self-care	about 90 min, in two sittings
Module 7: Every learner and every family	Inclusion, ELL, disability, culture, low-internet homes, family partnership, pushback	about 70 min
Module 8: Measure, reflect, grow + capstone	Pre/post, noticing growth, teach-back, action plan	about 75 min, plus the capstone (60 to 90 min)
Assessments, Certificate, Glossary, FAQ	Support documents	as needed

TIMES ARE ESTIMATES FOR a self-paced learner who reads the module, does the activities and one Scenario Studio case, and takes the self-check (the other cases make good staff-meeting discussions). Reading alone takes much less, but skip the "Do it yourself" boxes and you'll finish early and learn far less. Consider yourself warned.

Three pathways

PATHWAY A: QUICK START (90 MINUTES)

For: the teacher who starts teaching next week, or a staff meeting slot, or a sub-plan emergency. You will leave with enough to teach your first lesson safely.

STEP	WHAT TO DO	MINUTES
1	Take the 5-minute Pre-Course Confidence Survey (Academy_Assessments)	5
2	Module 1: read "The short version" and the four "Calm Facts" only	8
3	Module 2: do activities 2.1 (Password Makeover) and 2.2 (Phish or Real?)	20
4	Module 4: read "The five rules of safety teaching that works" and the "Good vs weak" table	8

STEP	WHAT TO DO	MINUTE S
5	Module 5: read "Anatomy of a 15-minute lesson" and do the Mini Micro-Teach (Activity 5.3) with a colleague	25
6	Module 6: read the First 10 Minutes card, say the key phrases out loud, and fill in your contact card	15
7	Take the Quick Start Mini-Check (Academy_Assessments)	4

Quick Start earns the **Quick Start Completion Note**, which is not the Hackles-Ready certificate. You're cleared to teach the lessons, and you can finish the Full pathway later.

FIELD NOTE	No. 2
Non-negotiable even in a hurry: before you teach a lesson with sensitive content, know your counselor's name, know who your school's reporting contact is, and read the First 10 Minutes card. Everything else can wait.	

PATHWAY B: FULL (8 MODULES, ABOUT 10 HOURS INCLUDING THE CAPSTONE)

For: everyone who wants to be Hackles-Ready. Work through Modules 1 to 8 in order, one module a week for eight weeks (about 60 to 90 minutes each) or in three half-days. Short and spaced beats one marathon, and that is the same spiral principle you'll be teaching your students later in the year.

Includes: pre-survey, all eight modules with self-checks, Modules 5 and 6 role-plays, a recorded or observed micro-teach, a capstone, and the post-survey. Earns the **Hackles-Ready Certificate**.

PATHWAY C: SPECIALIST (CS, COMPUTING AND IT TEACHERS)

For: teachers who already know the technology.

Skim the technical content in Module 2 (use the Specialist Challenge in each activity instead) and spend the time you save on Modules 4 to 8, where the skills for teaching, disclosure and inclusion live. Every module ends with a **Specialist Corner**, and together they build a short package:

MODULE	SPECIALIST CORNER FOCUS
1	Reading threat research critically; evidence literacy for your students
2	Teaching threat modeling, 2-step verification and passkeys without jargon; a safe phishing-simulation design
3	Platform walk-throughs without becoming the "platform police"
4	Turning technical labs into role-play-rich lessons
5	Co-teaching 15-minute lessons with classroom teachers
6	Being the school's "technical first responder" without viewing images
7	Accessibility and low-bandwidth lab design
8	Leading PD: running the Academy for your colleagues

Specialists earn the same Hackles-Ready Certificate and may pursue **Hackles Mentor** (see the Certificate and Badges document) by coaching colleagues. Estimated time: about 8 hours, plus mentoring.

The Competencies Framework: what a Hackles-Ready teacher can do

SIX COMPETENCY AREAS, EACH with "I can" statements. The module numbers show where each is taught. The capstone rubric assesses all six.

AREA	COMPETENCY	"I CAN..." STATEMENTS	TAUGHT IN
A. Know	Understand the landscape	I can describe the main risks kids face (scams, account takeover, unkindness online, pressure from strangers or near-strangers, sextortion, fake images, AI companions) in calm, accurate language. I can say which facts are well-supported and which I need to check.	M1, M3
B. Protect	Practice basic security	I can set up strong, unique passwords or passkeys, turn on 2-step verification, spot common phishing signs, update devices and make a simple backup. I can explain each in kid-friendly words.	M2
C. Connect	Meet kids where they are	I can ask about students' online lives with curiosity rather than judgment, and know what the popular spaces are used for.	M3
D. Teach	Use methods that work	I can design and run a 15-minute lesson built on skill practice: rehearsal, role-play, short discussion, a clear takeaway. I avoid fear appeals and shame. I can adapt for age.	M4, M5
E. Respond	Handle disclosures and incidents	I can run the First 10 Minutes, know my reporting duty, document correctly, hand off, and care for myself.	M6
F. Include and grow	Serve every learner and family, and keep improving	I can adapt for language, disability, culture and low-internet homes; partner with families; respond to pushback; and use simple measures to see if my teaching works.	M7, M8

PROFICIENCY LEVELS (USED IN THE CAPSTONE RUBRIC)

LEVEL	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Beginning	Can do it with a script or a colleague's support.
Developing	Can do it mostly alone, with some gaps.
Hackles-Ready	Can do it reliably, adapt it, and explain why.
Mentor	Can coach someone else to do it.

How the course teaches (so you know what to expect)

EVERY MODULE FOLLOWS THE same pattern, so you never have to wonder what comes next:

1. **Learning objectives:** what you will be able to do.
2. **Warm intro:** why it matters, with a bit of humor.
3. **Content:** short sections, with tables and scripts you can steal, and a 2 to 3 minute **Try This Now** where a module needs a stretch.
4. **Do it yourself:** two or three hands-on activities. Most use only fake data. Nothing asks for a real password, a real account, or a real student's information.
5. **Scenario Studio:** two or three realistic classroom dilemmas, each with a discussion prompt and "expert-response guidance" (a suggested approach, never the only right answer). Do at least one. Save the others for a staff meeting.
6. **Reflection prompts:** short, private and honest.
7. **Self-check:** 10 questions, answer key right below. (Cover the key first. We know you peeked.)
8. **Take Action this week:** a checklist of small real-world steps.
9. **Further reading:** with [VERIFY] flags where links or details need confirming.
10. **Quick Card:** a printable one-page summary at the end of each module.

STUDY ALONE OR WITH A PARTNER

The Academy works solo, but it works better with a colleague. Role-play and micro-teach need a partner (playing a child in a role-play is always optional; you can be the Teacher or the Observer), and a "learning buddy" helps you keep going. Staff-meeting groups of three or four are ideal: one teacher, one student actor, one observer, rotating.

WHAT "FAKE DATA ONLY" MEANS

Every hands-on activity uses invented people and invented accounts (for example the Lakeside Llamas Fan Club and a made-up game called Blockville). You will never be asked to type, share or screenshot a real password, a real student's name, or a real private image. Some activities ask you to look at your own settings, and they only ask you to look. Nothing is ever collected.

Earning the certificate

THE FULL DETAILS ARE in [Academy_Certificate_and_Badges](#). The short version:

REQUIREMENT	HACKLES-READY
Pre-Course Confidence Survey	Complete
Modules 1 to 8	Complete each, with self-check score of 8 out of 10 or better (retake allowed, and encouraged)
Micro-teach (Module 5)	Teach one 15-minute Hackles lesson or a 7-minute micro-version to a peer group and be observed with the rubric (peer or self-scored accepted)
First 10 Minutes role-play (Module 6)	Complete the role-play at least once as the teacher
Capstone (Module 8)	Submit or present the four capstone pieces, reaching "Hackles-Ready" on at least 5 of 6 rubric rows and no row at "Beginning"
Post-Course Confidence Survey	Complete

Quick Start earns a completion note only. **Hackles Mentor** requires holding Hackles-Ready, then coaching two colleagues through a micro-teach and the First 10 Minutes role-play, plus reflection.

The Academy runs on trust and costs nothing. A principal, coach, mentor or learning buddy signs the certificate, nobody is tracking you, no system stores your quiz results, and nobody will be told if you retake a quiz seven times.

The pathway ahead

HACKLES IS THE FIRST step on a path that continues with free resources such as picoCTF and CYBER.ORG. This note is for adults only and never appears in student materials.

A note about honesty

This course makes a few promises about itself:

- **It marks what it is unsure about.** Anything flagged [VERIFY] is a statistic, a law, a URL, a phone number or a standards code that you should confirm against the primary source before you quote it, print it or rely on it. Laws change, and so do apps and numbers. When in doubt, check the source and your district's policy.
- **It is not legal advice.** Mandated-reporting laws, timelines and procedures differ by state, district and school type. Where the Academy and your district policy disagree, follow your policy and tell your administrator the two should be aligned.

- **It is not clinical advice.** If you're worried about a child's immediate safety, you don't need a course. Call your counselor, your administrator, or 911 [VERIFY local procedures].
- **It tries not to scare you.** The goal is confident, calm teachers. If a module ever leaves you feeling dread, take a break, read the Module 6 self-care section, and come back.

Quick reference: the whole Hackles routine on one page

STEP	KID WORDS	TEACHER WORDS
Hackles up?	"Something feels off."	"Notice the feeling. Name it. Welcome false alarms."
Pause	"Stop. Breathe. Don't answer yet."	"Buy time. Nothing is urgent except real emergencies."
Check	"Is it real? Who is it from? What do they want?"	"Look at the sender, the ask, the pressure. Get a second pair of eyes."
Tell	"I tell a trusted person."	"Thank you for telling me. It's not your fault. You're not in trouble."

READY? OPEN MODULE 1. Take the pre-course survey first. It's the one place in the Academy where you get to be honest about how nervous you are, and it will feel good to look back on later.

This Academy is educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your district policy and counsel on reporting duties in your state.